THE BATTLE OF SLUYS

On June 22, 1340, the English king, Edward III, set sail across the North Sea from the Orwell estuary on board *Cog Thomas*, bound for the Scheldt in Belgium. His large fleet of round ships, balingers, galleys, and barges was packed with troops, although a party of high-born English ladies was also on board, being carried to the court of Edward's Flemish wife at Ghent. Joined by the English North Sea squadron under the command of Sir Robert Morley, Edward arrived off the Flanders coast to find a large French fleet anchored in the Scheldt estuary.

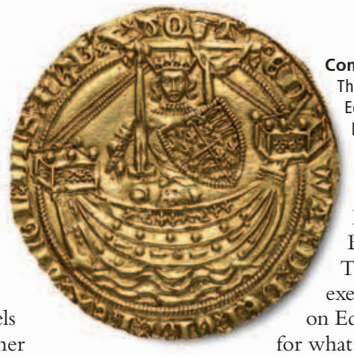
DEPLOYMENTS BEFORE THE BATTLE

According to the French chronicler Froissart, the king was astonished by the number of French ships, whose "masts resembled a forest." Commanded by Admiral Hugues Quiéret and by a lawyer, Nicolas Béhuchet, the French force had been assembled for an invasion of England. It included a contingent of Genoese galleys under the experienced mercenary naval commander Egidio Bocanegra, known as Barbavara. While the English waited for a favorable wind and tide to enter the estuary, the French placed their ships in a defensive formation, anchored in lines tied together with cables. The idea was to create a stable floating platform to be defended by the crossbowmen and men-at-arms. The *Christopher*, one of five large English ships recently captured by the French, was stationed in front of this mass, with Genoese crossbowmen manning her high castles. Barbavara, a true sailor, kept his own ships separate and maneuverable.

The English fleet was arranged with one ship packed with men-at-arms between each two ships of longbowmen. Maneuvering to approach with the sun and wind behind them, the English attacked at around noon on June 24. Both sides sounded trumpets, horns, and drums to encourage resolve as battle was joined. According to Froissart, "fierce fighting broke out on every side, with archers and crossbowmen shooting arrows and bolts at each other pell-mell, and men-at-arms struggling and striking in hand-to-hand combat." Iron grappling hooks were used to hold the enemy ships fast for boarding. The *Christopher* was one of the first vessels to be taken, and all her defenders were killed or captured.

CONTROL OF THE SEA

According to a letter written by King Edward after the battle, the fighting continued "all that day and the night after." The French clearly had the worst of it, possibly because of the rapid rate of fire and accuracy of the English king's longbowmen, or because the English ships were free to move around their anchored adversaries. It is no doubt significant that Barbavara's galleys were the only ships on the French side to escape the debacle, taking two prizes into the bargain.



Commemorative coin
This gold noble was issued by Edward III in the year of the battle of Sluys. It shows the king standing in a ship armed with a sword and shield.

Both Quiéret and Béhuchet were killed. The latter was possibly executed after the battle on Edward's orders, though for what reason is not known.

The sea was red with blood and thick with the bodies of French soldiers and sailors who had sought vainly to escape. The English victory, establishing naval dominance at the outset of the Hundred Years War, was strategically decisive, ensuring that the conflict would be fought in France, with little risk of a counter-invasion of England.

> "THE FRENCH SHIPS WERE ALL CHAINED TOGETHER, SO THAT THEY COULD NOT BE SEPARATED FROM ONE ANOTHER; THUS ONLY A FEW ENGLISH SHIPS WERE NEEDED TO GUARD ONE GROUP OF THOSE WHICH HAD BEEN ABANDONED."
>
> **GEOFFREY LE BAKER DE SWYNEBROKE**, ENGLISH CHRONICLER



A land battle fought on the sea
Sluys was not a battle of naval maneuver: the ships were effectively static and it was fought out by two armies of knights, men-at-arms, and archers.